BEING ASSERTIVE

Moderator Guide | Ranger Mastery Program - Day 3

A conversation about clear requests, respectful boundaries, and speaking up.

Audience: Support Engineers, Rangers, Escalation Engineers, Technical Leads

Suggested duration: 90 minutes | 6-10 participants
Conversation only | No written activities

1. Top learnings and conversation purpose

RMP Day 3 | Week 1: Mindset. Explore the RMP Being Assertive theme, inspired by TJ Guttormsen's *Becoming Assertive: Advocate for Your Interests*.

Learning objectives - through conversation, participants will:

- **Understand authentic assertiveness:** distinguish clear, connected self-expression from passivity, aggression, or forcing agreement.
- **Make needs and requests clear:** discuss how to name a decision, information need, constraint, or support request.
- **Set respectful boundaries:** explore realistic commitments and alternatives when a request cannot be met as stated.
- **Speak up constructively:** consider how to raise concerns across expertise, hierarchy, and organizational boundaries.
- **Make room for others:** recognize how listening, culture, and power affect whether assertiveness feels safe.

Expected outcome

Participants leave with a shared view of assertiveness as clear and respectful advocacy while paying genuine attention to others. They hear practical approaches to support requests, boundaries, and speaking up without turning the session into a performance or confidence test. There are **no written tasks, simulations, worksheets, tests, or required follow-up assignments**.

Suggested 90-minute conversation

Time	Conversation topic	Question at its heart
0-8	Welcome, objectives, and opening round	Where does this show up in our support work?
8-20	1. Clear without being forceful	What makes a support conversation feel assertive and respectful rather than passive or confrontational?
20-32	2. Ask for what is actually needed	What makes an internal support request easy for another person to understand and act on?
32-44	3. Boundaries without abandoning the customer	How can we say a request cannot be met as stated while still helping the customer move forward?
44-56	4. Speak up across hierarchy	What helps an engineer voice a concern when a more senior person has already chosen a direction?
56-68	5. Listen while advocating	What changes when we understand the need behind a request rather than only its wording?
68-80	6. A culture where clarity is safe	What team behaviors make it easier for people to ask, disagree, or say they need help?
80-90	Key takeaways and lessons learned	What changed or expanded our thinking?

Use: a flexible route, not a questionnaire to finish. Open with one question and choose follow-ups as needed. Examples are conversation starters, not exercises. The six topics are original support adaptations, not a claimed sequence from the source.

2. Conversation: assertiveness and requests

Topic 1 | Clear without being forceful - 8-20 min

Learning objective: Distinguish assertiveness from silence, aggression, or control.

Open the conversation: *"What makes a support conversation feel assertive and respectful rather than passive or confrontational?"*

Follow the conversation:

- Can someone be calm and still be very clear about a boundary?
- When do we confuse being helpful with agreeing to everything?
- How might communication style differ across cultures without indicating less confidence?

If a concrete example helps: A customer presses for an answer the engineer cannot yet confirm. Ask: *What would clear self-expression and genuine attention look like, without either surrendering accuracy or becoming defensive?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Rather than judge someone's personality or volume, which words or behaviors make the message clear and respectful?"*

Learning point to draw out: Assertiveness is not making another person agree. It is expressing a view, need, or limit while remaining connected to the other person.

Topic 2 | Ask for what is actually needed - 20-32 min

Learning objective: Discuss specific requests instead of vague appeals.

Open the conversation: *"What makes an internal support request easy for another person to understand and act on?"*

Follow the conversation:

- How do we name the decision or help needed, not just send a large amount of context?
- What impact, evidence, and timing make the request meaningful?
- How do we check whether the other person can actually accept it?

If a concrete example helps: An engineer sends *"Can someone look at this?"* to a busy escalation channel. Ask: *What would clarify the need without demanding attention or presuming capacity?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Instead of adding every case detail, what precise ask and response expectation are missing?"*

Learning point to draw out: A clear request connects context with an explicit need and realistic timing. Asking does not guarantee acceptance or transfer responsibility.

3. Conversation: boundaries and speaking up

Topic 3 | Boundaries without abandoning the customer - 32-44 min

Learning objective: Explore realistic limits and constructive alternatives.

Open the conversation: *"How can we say a request cannot be met as stated while still helping the customer move forward?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What can we acknowledge before stating a limit?
- Which alternative is within our authority and capacity?
- When is a boundary a policy or safety requirement rather than a personal preference?

If a concrete example helps: A customer asks for an immediate production change without the required review. Ask: *How could the engineer be clear about the limit and the next approved route, without sounding dismissive?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Let us focus on the boundary and available alternative, not whether the customer should have asked."*

Learning point to draw out: A respectful limit is explicit about what is possible and what happens next. Assertiveness does not override policy, safety, or required approvals.

Topic 4 | Speak up across hierarchy - 44-56 min

Learning objective: Consider how to raise a concern without attacking expertise or status.

Open the conversation: *"What helps an engineer voice a concern when a more senior person has already chosen a direction?"*

Follow the conversation:

- How can we distinguish an observed risk from a judgment about the person?
- What makes a disagreement easier to hear?
- What should happen if the concern is not acknowledged and the risk remains?

If a concrete example helps: A junior engineer notices a proposed test may disrupt a customer's production workload. Ask: *What would help the concern be heard, and what approved escalation route applies if it is dismissed?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Rather than decide who outranks whom, what concern needs acknowledgment and a safe decision?"*

Learning point to draw out: Speaking up is most useful when it names evidence, impact, and the needed decision. The organization must also provide safe ways to raise concerns.

4. Conversation: listening and team culture

Topic 5 | Listen while advocating - 56-68 min

Learning objective: Connect clear self-expression with curiosity about others' needs.

Open the conversation: *"What changes when we understand the need behind a request rather than only its wording?"*

Follow the conversation:

- How can we check our understanding without implying agreement?
- What might a receiving team's constraint look like from their side?
- How do we stay clear about our own need while learning about theirs?

If a concrete example helps: Another team repeatedly asks for an urgent call; the engineer thinks a written update is enough. Ask: *What might each side need, and how could they clarify that before arguing about the channel?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Before settling the answer, what have we not yet understood about each side's need?"*

Learning point to draw out: Listening and assertiveness reinforce each other. Understanding another view can improve the request without erasing your own boundary.

Topic 6 | A culture where clarity is safe - 68-80 min

Learning objective: Explore shared responsibility for participation and respectful response.

Open the conversation: *"What team behaviors make it easier for people to ask, disagree, or say they need help?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What happens when clear boundaries are labeled unhelpful or difficult?
- How can leads avoid rewarding only the fastest or loudest voice?
- What response would encourage someone to speak up again?

If a concrete example helps: A quiet engineer raises a capacity concern and is told to be more committed. Ask: *What would a supportive lead response look like, and what workload decision might actually be needed?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Let us not turn this into advice to be braver. What conditions make a clear request safe to make?"*

Learning point to draw out: Assertiveness is not only an individual skill. Respectful listening, fair workload decisions, and safe escalation make clear communication more usable.

5. Moderator's guide: keep it a conversation

Set the tone: opening eight minutes

Introduce the objectives and expected outcome. Say: *"This is a conversation, not an assessment. Different roles and regions will see this differently. Use fictional or anonymized work patterns, not customer details. You can pass, and I will make room for each voice."*

Use a short opening round: *"Where in support work is it hardest to say clearly what you need or what you cannot promise? A phrase or short example is enough."* Invite everyone once, allowing about 20-30 seconds each. Do not solve each case. Name one or two shared themes, then move to Topic 1.

Make participation broad, not forced

Aim for **6-10 participants**. With a larger group, use more round tables or allow more time. Rotate the first voice, invite different roles and shifts, and allow silence for thought. Everyone receives a genuine invitation, not an obligation to disclose or defend their ability.

What you notice	A useful moderator phrase
The same people answer first	"Thank you. Before adding more, let us hear from someone who has not spoken on this topic."
A quieter participant has not had space	"Would you like to add a view from your role or shift? Passing is completely fine."
A speaker runs long	"Let me pause there to make room for others. What is the main point you would like us to take from that?"
The conversation becomes a detailed case review	"We do not need to evaluate the person's confidence. What need, request, or boundary was unclear?"
A person or region is blamed	"Let us examine the work conditions and behaviors, not judge the person or team. What would help any engineer here?"
Participants disagree	"What is each person trying to express or protect, and how could both needs be heard?"
Discussion moves to an unrelated issue	"That matters, but it takes us away from today's objective. Can we connect it to this question, or leave it for the appropriate channel?"
There is silence	"Take a moment. Would the fictional support example help? What might be difficult in that situation?"

Bridge between topics

Reflect neutrally: *"I am hearing [theme], with a different experience around [difference]. Have I understood? That connects to our next question about [next topic]."* Do not manufacture agreement. Skip optional follow-ups if time is short rather than rush the closing round.

Boundaries: arrange live-queue coverage and follow normal incident and safety procedures. No customer identifiers, raw logs, credentials, personal health disclosures, or live technical changes. Acknowledge sensitive personal concerns and offer the appropriate private support route; do not investigate them in the round table.

6. Close: key takeaways and lessons learned

Key takeaways to connect back to the objectives

- **Be clear and connected.** Assertiveness is neither silence nor forcing agreement.
- **Name the actual need.** A specific request is easier to discuss than a vague appeal.
- **Limits can preserve trust.** Explain what is possible and the next approved route.
- **Concerns deserve a safe hearing.** Focus on evidence and impact, not status or personality.
- **Listening is part of advocacy.** Teams share responsibility for making participation safe.

Lessons-learned conversation: minutes 80-87

Invite a brief closing round, with the option to pass: *"What is one idea you are taking away, or one colleague's perspective that changed or expanded your thinking?"* Keep contributions short so everyone has space. No writing or public commitment is required.

If helpful, ask: *"Where might this help in daily support work?"* or *"What still needs team or leadership support?"* Reflect actual participant insights, not anticipated outcomes.

Examples to help the moderator recognize learning

A participant might say...	Connection to the learning objective
"Being clear does not mean making the other person agree."	Assertiveness: express a view without trying to control the response.
"I can state a limit and still offer a useful next step."	Boundaries: combine honesty with continuity and approved alternatives.
"The team response affects whether people speak up again."	Culture: support safe participation across roles and hierarchy.

Moderator wrap-up: minutes 87-90

Summarize two or three themes heard, acknowledge differences, and return to the objectives. Do not promise actions you cannot authorize.

Closing thought: *"Assertiveness in support is making the need, view, or limit clear while staying respectful of the other person and honest about what can happen next."*

Source and adaptation note

Inspired by TJ Guttormsen, *Becoming Assertive: Advocate for Your Interests* (52m), assigned for RMP Day 3. Public listing and opening lesson *A few words about the course* reviewed November 2, 2026; the complete course was not reviewed. These support examples and moderation prompts are original adaptations, not reproductions of the course's techniques or exercises.

RMP program materials | Course overview | Opening lesson